ABC-RI
Advocates for Better Care in Rhode Island

Choosing a Long-Term Care Residence

A visit guide: what to look for, what to ask, and where to find the data

Choosing a residence for yourself or a loved one is never easy. Visit more than once, at different times of day and on weekends. Talk with residents and families, and ask friends for their experiences. Then check the public data. Bring the checklist and questions with you on your visit. Use the links and QR codes below for research at home.

Research at home

Nursing homes
snfdashboard.abc-ri.org
Every home's star ratings, staffing, inspections, fines, and owners, with monthly history back to 2019. Each inspection links to the official report.

Assisted living residences
alinspections.abc-ri.org
What state inspections found at each residence, in plain language, with links to the original reports.

Which type of care?

Skilled nursing facilities (nursing homes) fit people who need most kinds of nursing care, or who need two or more staff to move in and out of bed. **Assisted living residences** fit people who need help with daily activities like bathing and dressing, or with managing medications (including insulin). They also provide housekeeping, laundry, transportation, activities, and meals. Some have secure units with special care for residents living with dementia. Rhode Island also has supportive residences for people with developmental disabilities and other special needs. They are not covered here.

What the data can tell you

Reading nursing home data

- **Inspections.** Surveyors cite deficiencies on a scale of A to L for how widespread and how harmful they were. G to I means actual harm. J, K, and L are "immediate jeopardy," the most serious. Look for fewer and less severe citations, and fewer substantiated complaints.
- **Star ratings.** Medicare gives each home 1 to 5 stars overall, plus separate stars for inspections, staffing, and quality measures. Complicated and imperfect, but a good place to start. **Many deficiencies go uncited.**
- **Staffing.** Look at total nursing hours per resident per day (nurses and nursing assistants combined). Higher means more hands on direct care. Residents with higher needs require more.
- **Turnover.** The share of nursing staff who leave each year. Lower turnover means more consistent care and usually happier staff.
- **Ownership.** Studies find that type of ownership affects quality of care.

Reading assisted living data

- **Inspections.** The state Department of Health (RIDOH) inspects each residence every two years, and more often when it receives a complaint. There is no scale of severity, the rules are fewer, and Rhode Island does not fine residences for violations. Look for fewer deficiencies, fewer complaint investigations, and less severe findings.
- **No star ratings.** Assisted living is regulated by the state only, not by Medicare. The inspection reports are the only data available.
- **Staffing.** RIDOH does not track staffing ratios or turnover. The law requires only "sufficient" staff to meet residents' needs. Ask for the numbers yourself (see the questions).
- **Bottom line.** Use the inspection data as a starting point, then spend as much time as you can visiting and asking around.

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Facility Visit Observation Checklist

Check the boxes as you walk through. Pay attention to what staff are doing *before* they notice you.

Good signs	Warning signs
THE BUILDING	
☐ Warm, homey feel	☐ Feels like an institution
☐ Residents can get outside	☐ Call lights blinking, beeping, or on for long stretches
☐ Residents move easily through halls and common areas	☐ Broken equipment, or hazards residents can reach
☐ Activities calendar is posted and followed	☐ Overflowing trash or laundry bins
☐ Well ventilated, with reasonable noise	☐ Loud or inappropriate noise (music, TV, intercom)
☐ Rooms are tidy and furnished with residents' own belongings	☐ Strong odors of urine, feces, disinfectant, or chemicals
☐ Shared community animals (dogs, cats, birds, fish)	☐ Slippery, sticky, or gritty floors
	☐ Too hot or too cold for residents
THE STAFF	
☐ Staff wear name badges	☐ Staff talking or texting on phones while on duty
☐ Staff smile at residents	☐ Residents yelling with no staff response
☐ Staff use residents' names and speak pleasantly and respectfully	☐ Staff chatting with each other and ignoring residents
☐ Staff knock and wait for permission before entering rooms	☐ Staff speak to residents in a demanding, dismissive, or unpleasant tone
	☐ Staff talk about residents in front of them
THE FOOD	
☐ Food looks and smells appetizing and nutritious	☐ Food trays left out well past mealtime
☐ Menu is posted and followed	
☐ Water pitchers and cups are within easy reach	
THE RESIDENTS	
☐ Hair, faces, hands, and nails are clean	☐ Residents in hospital gowns without need, or uncovered and exposed
☐ Dressed for the time of day, temperature, and season, in clean, well-fitted clothes	☐ Many residents in bed or "parked" near the nurses' station
☐ Taking part in group or independent activities	☐ Many residents asleep or slumped in wheelchairs
☐ Facility works with the community (libraries, parks, colleges, volunteers)	
☐ Regular outings	

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Questions You Might Ask

Pick the ones that matter most to you. Write down the answers, and ask the same questions at every place you visit.

Ask the administrator: leadership and staff

- ☐ May I have your cell phone number? What do you expect of yourself and your colleagues when residents and families call, message, or email?
- ☐ How long have you been the administrator here?
- ☐ What ongoing training do you give staff? Can you give recent examples?
- ☐ How do you make sure staff meet your expectations for resident care?
- ☐ What are you doing to keep good staff and bring down turnover?
- ☐ What share of staff are full-time? How often do you use per diem or agency staff?
- ☐ What is your ratio of residents to care staff, including nights and weekends? What about activity staff?
- ☐ How are assignments made? Will the same aides care for me or my loved one consistently?
- ☐ How many hours a week is your medical director here?

Ask the administrator: care and daily life

- ☐ What services are included in the rate? How and when are needs assessed and reassessed? What do added services cost?
- ☐ Here are my needs, preferences, and routines (for example, staying up late or a late breakfast). How will staff meet them?
- ☐ What programs help residents feel a sense of purpose? Are the activities meaningful (gardening, community service, chair yoga) or filler (an "ice cream social")?
- ☐ How do you ask residents about their satisfaction? How do you help residents make their own decisions about care, activities, and surroundings?
- ☐ Is there an independent resident council? What recent resident complaints were resolved?
- ☐ Do you have a family council? May I speak with its leader or members? How else do you support families?
- ☐ How do you coordinate on-site and off-site health care?
- ☐ What safety measures are in place if a resident needs emergency help? When are paramedics called or residents sent to the hospital?
- ☐ How do you prevent and manage COVID and other outbreaks?
- ☐ If relevant: how are roommates matched, and how are conflicts handled?
- ☐ What sets your facility apart for resident quality of life?
- ☐ Are you at full capacity? If not, why? If so, how long is the waiting list?

Ask staff

- ☐ How long have you worked here? Do you work at other facilities too?
- ☐ How many hours a week do you work? Do you ever work double shifts?
- ☐ What professional support does the facility give you?
- ☐ What is most challenging about your job?

Ask residents and families

- ☐ What are the best and worst things about living here?
- ☐ What changes would you like to see?
- ☐ How do you feel about the care, food, staff, leadership, activities, and your ability to make choices for yourself?

Dementia care units

- ☐ How does staff handle disruptive behaviors?
- ☐ How do you monitor residents' nutrition and sleep?
- ☐ Are there separate areas and activities for higher-functioning and lower-functioning residents?
- ☐ What is your policy on communicating with families and representatives?
- ☐ What would lead you to decide a resident is not a good fit, or that you cannot provide the care needed?
- ☐ Who trains staff on dementia-specific care?
- ☐ What is your ratio of residents to care staff, including nights and weekends? What about activity staff?
- ☐ *Nursing homes:* Is there a separate secured dementia unit? Is it licensed as a Special Care Unit? If not, why not?

Private pay

- ☐ Can I see your fees and rates for the last five years?
- ☐ How much notice do residents and families usually get before a rate increase?
- ☐ What happens when a resident runs out of money?

Before You Decide

Visiting tips

- **Go back unannounced, several times.** Include mealtimes, evenings, weekends, and shift change (around 3 pm).
- **Watch before you are noticed.** What are staff doing, and how do they talk to residents? Do they wear name tags? Are they following infection control?
- **Talk to people.** Speak with current residents and with any family or friends who are visiting. Ask your own friends and acquaintances about their experiences.
- **Look at the records.** Check the inspection history and ratings for every place you are considering (see the links below).

Before you sign

- **Medicaid.** Ask whether the facility accepts Medicaid. Ask for a written guarantee that you or your loved one can stay after "spending down" and switching to Medicaid.
- **Arbitration.** Ask whether you must sign a mandatory pre-dispute arbitration clause to be admitted. "Pre-dispute" means you agree to arbitration before any dispute arises, including abuse or neglect. If possible, choose a facility that does not require it.
- **Get it in writing.** Ask for the admission agreement and fee schedule to take home and read before you sign anything.

More data for research at home

Nursing home ratings, staffing, inspections, owners	snfdashboard.abc-ri.org
Assisted living inspection findings	alinspections.abc-ri.org
Official RIDOH inspection reports, assisted living	health.ri.gov/find/assistedliving
Official RIDOH information for nursing home residents and caregivers	health.ri.gov/nursing-homes
Medicare Care Compare (nursing homes)	medicare.gov/care-compare
ProPublica Nursing Home Inspect (Rhode Island)	projects.propublica.org/nursing-homes

Concerned about care, or need help?

Rhode Island's Long-Term Care Ombudsman Program advocates for residents of nursing homes and assisted living residences, listens to their concerns, and acts to protect their rights. To get help or to report suspected abuse, contact the Alliance for Better Long Term Care at **401-785-3340** or toll-free at **1-888-351-0808**. risltcop.org

Visit Notes

One block per visit. Note the day and time, who you spoke with, and what you saw and heard.

Facility _____ **Date and time** _____

Facility _____ **Date and time** _____

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